

LIFETIME ACHIEVEMENT

(Male)

Former India captain Nari Contractor was honoured with the Lifetime Achievement Award (Male).

Contractor received the honour from Sunil Gavaskar, chairman of the Sportstar Aces Awards jury, and Jayen Mehta (MD, Amul), as the packed ballroom rose in a standing ovation (pic, below).

Nariman Jamshedji "Nari" Contractor was among India's finest opening batters of the late 1950s and early 1960s. A stylish left-hander known for his compact technique and resolve, he made his Test debut in 1955 and went on to play 31 Tests, scoring 1,611 runs at an average of 31.58.

In 1961, aged just 26, Contractor became India's youngest Test captain at the time. Under his leadership, India secured a historic series victory over England in 1961-62.

Yet his career is remembered as much for bravery as for runs. During India's 1962 tour of the West Indies, Contractor suffered a life-threatening injury after being struck on the head by a bouncer from fast bowler Charlie Griffith. The blow fractured his skull and required multiple surgeries. He survived after several blood transfusions, including one from West Indies captain Frank Worrell.

Presenting the award, Gavaskar said it was "an incredible honour" to celebrate Contractor's legacy. He recalled how Contractor's courage had inspired him as a young boy, particularly during the 1959 Lord's Test when the opener continued batting for hours despite a broken rib after being struck by a delivery from Brian Statham.

Gavaskar also remembered a piece of advice from Contractor that stayed with him: "He once told me, 'Sunil, write down in a diary every time you do well what you did from the moment you woke up.

When you go through a bad patch, read that page again. It will give you the confidence that you can bat and score runs."

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